have been minus 15 degrees Celsius or so at about 1000 hours, but that was nothing compared to Bana Post, which had recorded a temperature of minus 47 degrees the previous night. After that, it was back to the Corps HQ for a formal briefing. I had planned to visit the other areas of Eastern Ladakh over the next two days, but that was not to be, as I was urgently recalled to the Capital due to a sudden requirement to go to Bhutan.

Ever since the Doklam stand-off, the People's Liberation Army (PLA) had been trying to construct a road coming South towards the Jampheri Ridge, in order to stake their claim to the area, disputed with Bhutan. Their earlier attempt along a shorter route closer to the International Border to the West was under observation by our own troops from our side of the border. The moment the PLA tried to alter the status quo, we had physically blocked the way leading to a seventy-three-day stand-off, before the PLA pulled back and gave up.[2] Instead, they commenced work on a road further to the East along the valley of the Amo Chu, which was not under our direct observation. We, of course, knew of this development through other sources, including satellite imagery. The latest inputs showed that they had now reached just short of Pt 1621, the junction between the Torsa Nala and the Amo Chu.[3] Any move further South would have grave and adverse security implications for India, as Bhutan lies just North of the strategically important Siliguri Corridor. It was felt that these developments should be shared with the Royal Government of Bhutan, in person to convey its gravity.

Accordingly, an under-the-radar visit was planned, with the delegation led by me and comprising Shri Vijay Gokhale, the Foreign Secretary, and Shri Samant Goel, Secretary Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW). All of us rushed off to Thimphu on 10 January and on arrival, after conferring

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